# Srila Ishvara Puri

*Ишвара Пури · @ishvara-puri*

## The Lord's Guru

Among the associates of Sri Chaitanya, Ishvara Puri holds a place that no one else can share with him: it was from him that the Lord enacted the pastime of accepting initiation. He is called Sri Ishvara Puripada, Sri Puripada, or simply Sri Puri; the Lord addressed him as “Sripada,” Sarvabhauma Bhattacharya spoke of him as “Puri Gosvami,” and an old verse extols him as the best of ascetics (yatis). “Ishvara Puri” is his sannyasa name; what name he was given at birth, no one knows.

He was the dearest disciple of Madhavendra Puri — so Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati also calls him in his commentary on the “Charitamrita” (Adi 9.10). Krishnadasa Kaviraja, depicting Sri Chaitanya's tree of devotion, places him second, after his guru:

“All glory to Sri Madhavendra Puri, the storehouse of pure loving service to Krishna! In him this desire tree of bhakti first sprouted.” (CC, Adi 9.10)

“And then this seed of the desire tree of bhakti took the form of a new sprout — Sri Ishvara Puri. And soon the Gardener Himself, Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu, became the main trunk of this tree of bhakti.” (CC, Adi 9.11)

In Madhavendra the seed of devotion first sprouted, in Ishvara Puri the sprout grew strong, and then the Gardener Himself became the trunk. The great souls say the same in other words: the root of the tree of shringara-rasa is Madhavendra, Ishvara Puri is its shoot, and Mahaprabhu is the main trunk.

His coming into the world was also part of the Lord's design. Before descending, Krishna sends ahead those whom He will honour as parents, teachers and elders:

“Before descending to the Earth, Krishna sends here many of His devotees, who accept the roles of His venerable forebears, teachers and elders.” (CC, Adi 3.92)

“Madhavendra Puri, Ishvara Puri, Srimati Shachimata and Jagannatha Mishra appeared together with Advaita Acharya.” (CC, Adi 3.94)

The “Charitamrita” lists the same circle of elders elsewhere too (Adi 13.53–55), and Lochana Dasa in the “Chaitanya-mangala” names Ishvara Puri and Madhavendra Puri among the eternal associates who descended together with the Lord. One of the biographies explains: Krishna sends His devotees before Him so that they may prepare the soil in which the preaching of love for Him will take root.

In the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” Kavi Karnapura speaks of him in two verses. Madhavendra there is the desire tree of Vraja bearing four fruits — servitude, friendship, parental and conjugal love — and the fruit of shringara went to Ishvara Puri:

“His disciple was the renunciate Sriman Ishvara Puri, who, being the fruit of conjugal love, manifested shringara.” (GGD 23)

“Gaura, reverently accepting Ishvara Puri as His guru, flooded the world, both material and spiritual.” (GGD 25)

Such a position is no matter of chance, nor the fruit of learning alone. Ishvara Puri was highly intelligent and deeply versed in the Vedas and the Vedanta; the world knew him also as a poet whose verse was learned and pure. But his fame rested on something else — a love for Krishna that knew no measure. The “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Adi 11.71) says of him: “He was overflowing with love for Krishna. He was dear to Krishna and exceedingly merciful.” In the guise of searching for Krishna he wandered

through Vraja, Navadvipa and other holy places that do not belong to this world.

## Kumarahatta

Ishvara Puri was born in Kumarahatta, in a family of Rarhi brahmanas; his father was the pious Sri Shyamasundara Acharya. Kumarahatta lies between Calcutta and Navadvipa-Mayapur, in the district of the Twenty-Four Parganas, a few miles north of Calcutta near the railway town of Kanchrapara; today it is Halisahar, and the station of that name stands about two miles from the place[1].

According to one of the biographies, he appeared on the full-moon day of the month of Jyaishtha[2]. He was born in the Mukhopadhyaya-para quarter; nearby Srivasa Pandita later settled, so that his birthplace came to be identified with Srivasa's dwelling. Of this place, which became a holy site, more will be said below.

## Disciple of Madhavendra

From Madhavendra Puri, Ishvara Puri accepted sannyasa[3], and from then on he gave himself wholeheartedly and in every way to the service of his guru. Madhavendra was pleased with his guileless, sincere and loving service and blessed him generously, and that blessing plunged the disciple into the ocean of love for Krishna. In the lists of Madhavendra's disciples his name stands first: Ishvara Puri, Advaita, Paramananda Puri, Brahmananda Puri, Sri Ranga Puri, Pundarika Vidyanidhi, Raghupati Upadhyaya and others; Srila Bhaktisiddhanta names Ishvara Puri, Nityananda and Advaita as the chief among them, and a Bengali verse echoes this: the best of the Puris is Madhavendra, and the best of his disciples are Sri Ishvara, Nityananda and the master Advaita.

The “Bhakti-ratnakara” (5.2272–2273) writes that Ishvara Puri, Ranga Puri and all of Madhavendra's disciples were intoxicated with the taste of bhakti, as was their guru. Yet before true joy came to them, they had to know sorrow: among those whom the world called saints they found not a trace of love for Krishna, and they wandered through the forests without consolation. Consolation came when their guru met Nityananda.

This happened somewhere in western India, in the years when Nityananda was travelling to the holy places. On seeing each other, Madhavendra and Nityananda fell unconscious with love, and Ishvara Puri, standing nearby with Brahmananda Puri and other disciples, wept — so overwhelmed was he by that love (CB, Adi 9.161). And when both came to themselves and embraced tightly, Ishvara Puri and Brahmananda became attached to Nityananda with all their hearts: they saw how dear He was to their guru (CB, Adi 9.170). Their sorrow was dispelled, and for many days Nityananda stayed with Madhavendra, Ishvara Puri and Brahmananda Puri in talks about Krishna.

The highest service fell to him in Madhavendra's last days. Madhavendra could no longer move, and of all the disciples Ishvara Puri served him best. He never left his guru's side, chanted Krishna's name to him and sang of Krishna's glories and pastimes, and when it was needed he cleaned away his urine and stool with his own hands (CC, Antya 8.26–27). The commentary of Srila Bhaktivedanta Svami, on which one of the biographies draws, explains: a Vaishnava is always protected by the Lord, and if he appears infirm, this only gives his disciples the chance to serve; and by the guru's mercy the disciple attains perfection.

Madhavendra answered this service with a blessing that shaped the whole of his disciple's later life:

“Fully pleased with Ishvara Puri, Madhavendra Puri embraced him and blessed him: ‘May you obtain all the wealth of divine love for Krishna.’

Thus Ishvara Puri became like an ocean of love for Krishna, while Ramachandra Puri became an inveterate critic.

Thus these two disciples became a testimony to the consequences of the blessing and the rejection of a true saint. Through them Madhavendra Puri taught a lesson to the people of the whole world." (CC, Antya 8.28–30)[4]

The lesson is simple and stern: whoever pleases the guru obtains all that is auspicious; whoever angers him obtains only the inauspicious. Both disciples were present at Madhavendra's departure, and both became a living example of his teaching.

Having blessed his disciple, Madhavendra left his body repeating a verse that holds the whole thirst of separation from Krishna:

"O merciful Lord, ever kind to the afflicted, O master of Mathura, when shall I see You again? In separation from You my heart is breaking. O Beloved! What am I to do?" (CC, Antya 8.32)

This verse, "ayi dīna-dayārdra nātha," has never since left the lips of pure devotees. The "Chaitanya-bhagavata" sums it up: "Sri Madhavendra Puri joyfully passed on the treasure of ecstatic love to his disciple — Sri Ishvara Puri" (CB, Adi 11.125–126).

## An Unrecognized Guest in Navadvipa

Ishvara Puri came to Navadvipa at the time when Nimai Pandita was absorbed in study and was already known as a scholar and teacher. He came concealing his name, his abode and who he was, so that no one would discern a Vaishnava in him; and he was not dressed as sannyasis dress, so that he truly could not be recognized (CB, Adi 11.70–72). Chance — or rather the will of Providence — brought him to the house of Advaita Acharya.

There, where Advaita performed His puja and where people gathered to speak of Krishna's glories, the guest sat humbly, almost timidly, to one side. Again and again Advaita looked up from His worship and gazed at him: the radiance of a Vaishnava cannot be hidden from a Vaishnava, and Advaita, Himself a disciple of Madhavendra, at once recognized in the stranger the familiar features of a godbrother. Concluding within Himself that this was a pure Vaishnava, He approached and asked humbly, "Who are you, O dear sir? I think that you are a Vaishnava sannyasi" (CB, Adi 11.75).

The guest replied: "I am lower than a shudra. I have come here only to see Your lotus feet" (CB, Adi 11.76). A brahmana by birth and a sannyasi by ashrama, he spoke of himself so without a trace of pose — and by this a great Vaishnava is known. Humility is the true ornament of a Vaishnava, and he who was the jewel of the learned and the best of the renounced wore it naturally.

Mukunda Datta, a constant member of the gatherings at Advaita's house, sensed that a great Vaishnava was before them and, to reveal him, began to sing a verse about Krishna's glory. The moment the song touched Ishvara Puri's ears, he fell to the ground, and tears poured from his eyes in an unceasing stream. Advaita hastily caught him in His arms (according to one account, lifted him onto His lap), and soon was Himself drenched with his tears (CB, Adi 11.77–80). Waves of love rose in Advaita too; the devotees were struck dumb with wonder and said they had never seen such a Vaishnava anywhere. Little by little they learned that this was Ishvara Puri, the dearest disciple of Madhavendra, and they cried out jubilantly, "Hari! Hari!"

## Nimai Pandita and the "Krishna-lilamrita"

One day Nimai, returning from school, met Ishvara Puri on the road and, seeing His eternal servant, bowed down before him[5]. The sannyasi was struck by His beauty and majestic gravity and asked, "O best of brahmanas, what is Your name? What do You study and what do You teach? Where is Your home?" Those accompanying the Lord answered, "This is Nimai Pandita," and Ishvara Puri said joyfully, "So, You are Nimai!" (CB, Adi 11.85–91).

Nimai invited him to a meal and with great love brought him to His home; according to one account, He Himself washed His guest's feet, saying, “Sripada, be merciful.” Mother Shachi cooked bhoga for Krishna, and Ishvara Puri honoured the prasada; the Lord, after offering the food to the Deity, partook of it as well. Then, honouring his host's hospitality, the guest lingered in the room of the household shrine and began to speak of Krishna's glory. As he spoke, the rapture of love grew in him; his body grew weak, but he, as befits a true Vaishnava, tried to hide it — not like hypocrites who display trembling so that honour may be paid them. The Lord rejoiced to see his tears, the sign of a deep love for God which he hid from worldly eyes (CB, Adi 11.92–95). Long they spoke of Krishna, and love flooded both hearts.

At the earnest request of Gopinatha Acharya, Ishvara Puri settled in his house and lived there for several months[6] (CB, Adi 11.96). All the devotees came to him; the Lord came too — after His studies and lessons He would come to pay His respects[7], and the Lord would often call him to His home, and he would call the Lord to his.

He grew especially fond of Gadadhara Pandita, then still a boy: from childhood he had seen in him tears of love and a deep detachment from the world. He began to teach Gadadhara from the manuscript of his own book — the “Sri Krishna-lilamrita,” an account of Krishna's deeds. The “Bhakti-ratnakara” (12.2205–2207) adds that it was in the house of Gopinatha Acharya, where Vishvambhara would come from time to time, that Ishvara Puri wrote it.

One evening, when the Lord came as usual, Ishvara Puri smilingly handed Him the manuscript: “You are the greatest of scholars. I have written a book about the glories of Krishna. Please listen to it and note the mistakes I have made. By this You will give me the greatest joy” (CB, Adi 11.103–104). The Lord's answer is one of the most precious teachings of the “Chaitanya-bhagavata”:

“One who sees faults in the way a devotee speaks of Krishna is a sinner. Krishna is always pleased with the poetic praises written by His devotee, even if they contain some imperfections. The uneducated will say ‘vishnaya,’ and the learned ‘vishnave,’ yet the Supreme Lord Krishna accepts both expressions if He is called with devotion.” (CB, Adi 11.105–107)

One who looks for faults in a devotee is himself full of faults; who would dare to judge a description of Krishna's pastimes born of love (CB, Adi 11.109–110)? The words of devotees do not belong to this world: their letters are taken from the alphabet of Krishna Himself, and therefore they are perfect.

At these words it was as though nectar spread through Ishvara Puri's heart. Smiling, he still insisted: “There will be nothing wrong if You point out the possible mistakes in my book” (CB, Adi 11.112). From then on Nimai spent an hour or two with him every day in such conversations (CB, Adi 11.113). Once the Lord pointed out a grammatical irregularity: a verbal root, He said, stood in the wrong voice. Ishvara Puri, himself a great scholar, justified his usage the next day by all the rules, and the Lord, acknowledging him right, looked for no more faults in the book[8]: the glory of His devotee always pleases Him more than His own (CB, Adi 11.114–121).

According to one of the biographies, Ishvara Puri then understood that Nimai was the Supreme Lord Himself[9]. For several months he relished learned conversations with Gaurasundara, and then — according to that same biography, with a few devotees — he left Navadvipa to continue his pilgrimage: love, which does not let one stay long in one place, led him on (CB, Adi 11.122–123).

## Gaya

Time passed, and the Lord came to Gaya to perform the gaya-shraddha for His recently departed father, Jagannatha Mishra. Here He unexpectedly met Ishvara Puri (CC, Adi 17.8): no one had known beforehand that he was in Gaya — the Lord Himself had moved his mind to come there. At the feet of

Vishnu, hearing the brahmanas speak of the glory of those feet, the Lord drowned in love, and at that moment, obeying His divine will, Ishvara Puri came there (CB, Adi 17.42–46). According to one account, the Lord then fell unconscious, and Ishvara Puri, seeing Him, was struck dumb; Chandrashekhara Acharya was nearby. Coming to Himself, the Lord saw Ishvara Puri and bowed to him; they embraced in great joy, and the tears of each bathed the other (CB, Adi 17.47–49).

Then the Lord said: “My journey to Gaya reached its goal the moment I saw your lotus feet. If a person makes an offering to the ancestors at a holy place, they attain liberation. In this way only those to whom the sanctified food is offered can be liberated. But it is enough simply to see you, and millions of ancestors are at once freed from material bondage. The holy places cannot compare with you, for you are able to purify them. Please save Me from the ocean of material existence. I surrender to you! I beg you: let Me drink the nectar of Krishna's lotus feet” (CB, Adi 17.50–55). According to one of the biographies, the Lord also said: the holy places pray for the dust of your feet — and so do I; I give this body to you.

Ishvara Puri replied that he knew for certain that the One before him was of the Lord Himself[10]; otherwise where would such learning and such qualities come from? And he went on: “Last night I had a wondrous dream, and today I have obtained its fruit. O Pandita! Every moment of Your company I experience the greatest bliss. Since the day I saw You in Nadia, there has been no room left in my heart for any other attraction. Believe me, I speak the truth: when I see You, I remember Lord Krishna.” Hearing the truthful words of His beloved devotee, the Lord smiled and said, “I am extraordinarily fortunate” (CB, Adi 17.56–62).

With Ishvara Puri's permission the Lord — in the role of an ordinary pilgrim who had come to honour His departed father — went to perform the shraddha and the accompanying rites. Having completed them, He returned to His lodging, rested and began to cook. Just as the food was ready, Ishvara Puri arrived, chanting the names of Krishna. The Lord gave him everything He had cooked for Himself; the guest offered to share the food equally, but the Lord insisted that he eat alone, and began to cook again for Himself. Afterwards He Himself anointed His guest's body with sandalwood paste (CB, Adi 17.80–96)[11]. Thus the Lord showed perfectly how to serve the guru: service to the guru is the gateway to devotion, and one who does not know how to honour a saint will not attain prema.

The next day the Lord came to Ishvara Puri alone and with deep reverence asked him for mantra-diksha. Ishvara Puri answered: “What to speak of a mantra? I am ready to give You my life” (CB, Adi 17.105–106). And the Lord, “wishing to teach the whole world,” accepted from him the ten-syllable mantra (CB, Adi 17.107)[12].

The Lord, Bhagavan Himself, needs no teacher. But He became a disciple so that the world would understand: without taking shelter of a genuine guru there is neither pure devotion nor the highest good, and one must know how to conduct oneself with the guru. This alone — that the Lord chose him as His guru — shows Ishvara Puri's greatness. After the initiation the Lord stayed with him for some time with deep reverence, and then, by his instruction, left Gaya for Navadvipa.

Of what followed the “Charitamrita” speaks briefly: “And immediately after initiation by the Guru, love for Krishna manifested in Him. And when He returned home, it took complete possession of Him” (CC, Adi 17.9). With Gaya begin the pastimes of love and the sankirtana. The place of initiation at the feet of Vishnu in Gaya was not forgotten later: on their way to Vrindavana both Srinivasa Acharya and Shyamananda (Duhkhi Krishnadasa) bowed there to the feet of Vishnu — Shyamananda, remembering how Ishvara Puri had given the Lord the mantra, was overwhelmed with ecstasy; and Madhavendra came to be spoken of as the one whose disciple Ishvara Puri gave the Lord diksha in Gaya.

## The Dust of Kumarahatta

The Lord did not forget His guru's homeland either. He came to Kumarahatta[13] and, as the "Chaitanya-bhagavata" relates (Adi 17.98–102), bowed down to the village where Ishvara Puri was born; He wept there, repeating his name again and again, and then took a handful of earth from his birthplace and tied it in the end of His cloth: "The dust of Ishvara Puri's birthplace is My life, My wealth and My very life-force." According to one account, He prostrated Himself full length before this place as before a tirtha and uttered not a word but one — "guru." Thus the Lord taught how to honour the guru's homeland.

Ever since, down to our own days, following the Lord's example, people take earth from there — both true followers and those who only call themselves such. A hollow formed on the spot, and then a pond; it is called just that — "Chaitanya-doba," "Chaitanya's pond."

After the Lord's sannyasa, Srivasa Pandita moved to Kumarahatta with his whole family and his brothers and settled near Ishvara Puri's birthplace; opposite the Chaitanya-doba stands the temple "Devalaya," marked as Srivasa's dwelling. People still take earth here, but many have forgotten that the Lord took it from His guru's birthplace. Other associates of the Lord lived in Kumarahatta, Ishvara Puri's native town: Shivananda Sena and the lame Bhagavan — apparently Bhagavan Acharya, whom the "Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika" (74) calls a portion of Gaura; and Mukunda and Vasudeva Datta moved here after the Lord's sannyasa, calling this place "the original abode of Ishvara Puripada."

## Last Years

Of his later life little is known. From pilgrims coming from Navadvipa he heard that after Gaya Nimai had become utterly changed: He was always absorbed in love for Krishna, sang His name and glories and bathed everyone around Him with tears, and the devotees had understood that Krishna Himself had descended to save the people of the age of Kali. Ishvara Puri was overjoyed. According to one of the biographies, the news also reached him that the Lord had accepted sannyasa from Keshava Bharati, received the name Sri Krishna Chaitanya and settled in Puri; another biography says that by then he had already completed his service in the Lord's manifest pastimes. No source names the day, the year or the place of his departure[14].

Only his last instruction is known. He had two dear disciples — the brahmachari Kashishvara and Govinda, his beloved servant; both served their guru as long as he remained in this world.

"Before his departure Ishvara Puri ordered Kashishvara and Sri Govinda to go to Jagannatha Puri and meet Sri Chaitanya there." (CC, Adi 10.139)

Govinda set out at once and found the Lord already returned from His journey through the South; Kashishvara came later, after first visiting the holy places. Govinda said: "My name is Govinda and I am the servant of Ishvara Puri. By the order of my guru I have come to You. Just before his departure from this world Ishvara Puri ordered me to find Sri Krishna Chaitanya and become His servant" (CC, Madhya 10.132–133). The Lord replied: "Sri Ishvara Puri always treated Me with parental love. Therefore in his sending you to Me I see his causeless mercy" (CC, Madhya 10.135).

Yet the Lord hesitated to accept their service: they were His godbrothers, servants of His guru, and themselves worthy of respect. Sarvabhauma persuaded Him that a guru's order must not be broken, and the Lord, taking into account Ishvara Puri's command, agreed (CC, Madhya 10.142–145). At that time Sarvabhauma also asked why Puri Gosvami had kept as his servant a man from a shudra family. The Lord answered: those like Ishvara Puri are independent, like the Supreme Himself; their mercy is not subject to Vedic injunctions and does not look at caste — for Krishna, too, accepted food in the house of Vidura, a shudra by his mother. Krishna's mercy is guided by love alone, and service in love is millions of times sweeter than service out of fear and reverence (CC, Madhya 10.136–140). From then on

Govinda cared for the Lord's body, while the mighty Kashishvara walked ahead when the Lord went to the temple of Jagannatha and parted the crowd with his arms so that no one would jostle Him (CC, Adi 10.140–142).

## In Madhavendra's Circle

Ishvara Puri was bound by ties of spiritual kinship to many of the Lord's associates, and the Lord honoured them for his sake. Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura writes that Advaita was a godbrother of the Lord's guru, Ishvara Puri, and therefore the Lord honoured Advaita as an elder; Advaita, after all, also played the role of Madhavendra's disciple. For the same reason the Lord honoured Paramananda Puri as His guru. And Sri Ranga Puri, meeting the Lord in the South, was filled with tenderness towards Him as soon as he learned that He was a disciple of Ishvara Puri (CC, Madhya 9).

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta says: the Lord, the guru of the whole world, accepted Ishvara Puri as His guru in order to honour him. And the Lord Himself treasured what He had heard from him: in Remuna He told His companions the story of Madhavendra and Gopala as He had heard it from the lips of His guru (CC, Madhya 4).

Later works, which must be approached with caution, add a good deal more[15]. The “Prema-vilasa” calls Ishvara Puri the guru of Nityananda (according to other accounts, Nityananda was a disciple of Madhavendra or of Lakshmipati): in its telling, a sannyasi asked Hadai Pandita for his son as alms, so that the boy might guide him through the holy places, and after visiting the tirthas told Him to seek out the son of Nanda who had descended in Navadvipa. It also says that Vishvarupa accepted sannyasa from him, receiving the name Shankararanya, and invested His power in him so that he might pass it on to Nityananda. Jayananda in his “Chaitanya-mangala” relates that Nityananda accepted sannyasa from Ishvara Puri at Prayaga, and the “Advaita-prakasha” calls him “an incarnation of ujjvala-rasa” and says that in Navadvipa he stayed with Advaita.

The biographies of the Lord's associates invariably place his name among the chief heroes of their narrative, alongside the names of his guru and his godbrothers.

## Significance

Ishvara Puri lived a life of which the sources say little, and almost nothing of his own deeds apart from his meetings with the Lord and with Madhavendra. But even this little is enough. By his service to his dying guru he became an “ocean of love” and the heir to Madhavendra's treasury; in him the sprout of devotion that first sprouted in his guru grew strong and became a support for the trunk — Mahaprabhu Himself. His humility (“I am lower than a shudra”), his hidden ecstasy that he never put on show, his love for Gadadhara and for Nityananda — these are the traits of a Vaishnava of whom the Lord said, “It is enough simply to see you, and millions of ancestors are at once freed from material bondage.”

And yet his chief glory is the one the Lord Himself bestowed on him. Accepting the mantra from him, bowing to the dust of his homeland, accepting the service of his disciples as the guru's will, Sri Chaitanya showed the world what it means to be a disciple, and thereby placed Ishvara Puri for ever beside Himself: “Gaura, reverently accepting Ishvara Puri as His guru, flooded the world, both material and spiritual” (GGD 25).

**1.** One of the biographies, citing Srila Bhaktisiddhanta, names two stations here — Kamarhati and neighbouring Halisahar; the others identify Kumarahatta with Halisahar.

**2.** The other biographies do not name the day of his appearance. Our calendar (vaishnavacalendar.org, Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math) has neither his appearance nor his disappearance day; on the full moon of the month of Trivikrama (Jyaishtha) it marks the Snana-yatra and the departure of Mukunda Datta and Sridhara Pandita.

**3.** So in one of the biographies; another speaks of initiation, a third only says that he was Madhavendra's disciple.

**4.** One of the biographies gives the reference here as “Charitamrita,” Madhya 8.29 — it should read Antya 8.29; another cites Antya 8.32 for the story of the two disciples, though that is the number of the verse “ayi dīna-dayārdra,” while the two witnesses are spoken of in Antya 8.30.

**5.** So in the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Adi 11.85–86) and in two biographies; according to the third, Gauranga first saw him in the same place, at Advaita's house.

**6.** According to one of the biographies — a month.

**7.** According to the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Adi 11.101) — in the evening, after lessons; one biography says the Lord came every day around sunrise, another that He came daily to Gopinatha Acharya's house when Ishvara Puri was teaching Gadadhara.

**8.** According to one of the biographies, the Lord approved both Ishvara Puri's argument and His own remark; according to another, He praised the book highly as flawless, but, yielding to the author's insistence, made a few corrections in it with His own hand.

**9.** The “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Adi 11.102), on the contrary, says that in Navadvipa Ishvara Puri loved Nimai without yet understanding that the Supreme Lord Himself was before him; compare his words in Gaya: “Since the day I saw You in Nadia, there has been no room left in my heart for any other attraction” (Adi 17.60).

**10.** The original of the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Adi 17.56) reads *tumi ye īśvara-aṁśa*: “You are an aṁśa (part, manifestation) of the Lord”; our translation has “an expansion of the Supreme Personality of Godhead.” One of the biographies renders these words as an acknowledgement of Bhagavan Himself in full, another as “a deity who has descended among men.” The guru speaks with restraint: the Lord is still concealing Himself in the role of a disciple. Gaudiya Vaishnavas, following the “Charitamrita,” know Sri Chaitanya as Krishna Himself, Svayam Bhagavan.

**11.** According to one of the biographies, this meal took place after the initiation: one day Ishvara Puri came to the Lord, and He begged him to stay for a meal, cooked and fed him Himself, anointed him with sandalwood and offered him a garland. The “Chaitanya-bhagavata” and the other biographies place it before the initiation.

**12.** So in the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” and in two biographies; the third calls the mantra “gayatri” and gives the Lord's request in the words “Without it My mind is restless,” and places the request a few days after the meeting. In Lochana Dasa's “Chaitanya-mangala” it is “the mantra of Krishna,” “the great mantra of Gopinatha”; there the Lord meets Ishvara Puri on the way to the feet of Vishnu, before the rites, begs him for mercy and at once receives the mantra — and the bhavas of Vraja awaken in Him; a few days later He returns home (CM, Adi-khanda, part 15, vv. 57–75).

**13.** The sources differ as to when this happened. The “Chaitanya-bhagavata” tells of it in the chapter on Gaya; according to one biography, the Lord came to Kumarahatta on His way back from Gaya to Navadvipa and watered the ground with His tears; according to another — on the way to Puri, after which He went to Srivasa's house; according to a third — years later, on the way to Vrindavana through Gauda.

**14.** According to one of the biographies, he still lived to hear of the Lord's sannyasa and His life in Puri; according to another, when the Lord after His sannyasa went to Puri at His mother's bidding, Ishvara Puri had already left this world. Govinda, according to the “Charitamrita” (Madhya 10), came to the Lord after His return from the South.

**15.** The “Prema-vilasa” and Jayananda's “Chaitanya-mangala” are late sources, and the “Advaita-prakasha” is among the least reliable; their accounts are not confirmed by the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” and the “Charitamrita,” and therefore they are accepted with caution. The “Prema-vilasa” itself elsewhere names Ishvara Puri of Kumarahatta and Keshava Bharati as Mahaprabhu's teachers.